Unit -3

Emergence of New Kingdoms in South India: Later Cholas and Pandyas



Learning Objectives

- To trace the origin of the later Cholas and the later Pandyas
- To know about the prominent rulers of both the kingdoms
- To acquaint with their administrative system
- To understand the social, economic and cultural development during their reign

I. The Later Cholas

Introduction

The Cholas are one among the popular and well-known Tamil monarchs in the history of South India. The elaborate state structure, the extensive irrigation network, the vast number of temples they built, their great contributions to art and architecture and their overseas exploits have given them a pre-eminent position in history.

Revival of the Chola Rule

The ancient Chola kingdom reigned supreme with the Kaveri delta forming the core area of its rule and with Uraiyur *(present-day Tiruchirappalli)* as its capital. It rose to prominence during the reign of Karikala but gradually declined under his successors. In the 9th century Vijayalaya, ruling over a small territory lying north of the Kaveri, revived the Chola Dynasty. He conquered Thanjavur and made it his capital. Later Rajendra I and his successors ruled the empire from Gangaikonda Cholapuram, the newly built capital.

Rajaraja I (A.D. (CE) 985 - 1014) was the most powerful ruler of Chola empire and also grew popular beyond his times. He established Chola authority over large parts of South India. His much-acclaimed naval expeditions led to the expansion of Cholas into the West Coast and Sri Lanka. He built the famous Rajarajeswaram (Brihadeshwara) Temple in Thanjavur. His son and successor, Rajendra Chola I (A.D. (CE) 1014 - 1044, matched his father in his ability to expand the empire. The Chola empire remained a powerful force in South India during his reign.

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